NEW YORK

The Empire State



The Mohawk Valley of upstate New York has never been glamorous. Carved out by glaciers and later by the Erie Canal, it became a corridor for ambition—waves of immigrants moving through or planting roots in the small industrial cities that grew along its banks. Utica, sitting at the valley's heart, became one of those cities where people stayed, worked, and eventually fed each other in ways that outlasted the factories that first drew them there.

The Italians arrived in significant numbers beginning in the 1880s, settling primarily in Utica's East Side neighborhood, a tight grid of row houses and corner stores that smelled of garlic and Sunday gravy. They came mostly from southern Italy—Calabria, Sicily, Campania—regions where food was not recreation but identity, where a family's worth was measured in part by what came out of its kitchen. They brought with them a reverence for simple ingredients transformed by patience: good olive oil, hand-rolled pasta, tomatoes cooked low and long until they became something richer than themselves.

Rigatoni was already at home in those kitchens. Sturdy, ridged, built to hold sauce in its grooves and hollows, it was the working pasta of southern Italy—honest and unfussy. In Utica, it found a new companion in the bold, slightly sweet cherry peppers that Italian immigrant families began growing in their backyard gardens, adapting to the shorter upstate growing season. Those peppers—roasted until their skins blistered and their heat mellowed into something complex and lingering—became a signature of Utica Italian cooking, showing up in dishes that existed nowhere else in the country.

The exact origin of Chicken Riggies is debated the way all beloved local dishes are, with several Utica restaurants and home cooks claiming credit through the 1970s and 1980s. What is clear is that the dish—rigatoni tossed with tender chunks of chicken, cherry peppers, and a rich, slightly spicy tomato cream sauce—was born from the instincts of Italian American home cooks who were doing what their grandmothers had always done: using what was available, building flavors in layers, and feeding people generously. It spread from kitchen to kitchen, then restaurant to restaurant, until it became so thoroughly Utica's own that the city now holds an annual Riggie Cook-Off drawing competitors from across the region.

What makes Chicken Riggies worth making—worth seeking out the right peppers, worth letting the sauce reduce properly—is that it delivers something rare: a dish with genuine character. It is creamy without being heavy, spicy without overwhelming, deeply savory with just enough sweetness from the peppers to keep every bite interesting. Make it once and you will understand immediately why a small upstate city has been fiercely proud of it for decades. Make it for company and you won't have to explain a thing—the pot will be empty before you do.

CHICKEN RIGGIES

A steaming bowl of tender chicken and rigatoni, wrapped in spicy, creamy tomato sauce, is pure Utica comfort in every bite.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb. rigatoni pasta
- 1½ lb. boneless, skinless chicken breast, cubed
- 2 Tbsp olive oil
- 1 small onion, diced
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 red bell pepper, sliced
- 1 green bell pepper, sliced
- 3–4 hot cherry peppers, sliced (adjust to taste)
- ½ cup dry white wine (or chicken broth)
- 1 (15 oz.) can crushed tomatoes
- 1 tsp dried oregano
- 1 tsp crushed red pepper flakes (optional, for extra heat)
- ½ cup heavy cream
- ¼ cup grated Parmesan cheese, plus more for serving
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 1 bunch fresh parsley, for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Cook the pasta*: Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil. Cook rigatoni until al dente. Drain and set aside, reserving ½ cup of pasta water.
2. *Sear the chicken*: In a large skillet or sauté pan, heat olive oil over medium-high heat. Season chicken with salt and pepper, then cook until golden brown and just cooked through, 5–7 minutes. Remove and set aside.
3. *Sauté vegetables*: In the same skillet, add onion, garlic, and bell peppers. Cook until softened, 4 minutes. Add hot cherry peppers and cook 1–2 minutes more.
4. *Deglaze and simmer*: Pour in white wine (or broth) to deglaze the pan, scraping up any browned bits. Stir in crushed tomatoes, oregano, and crushed red pepper flakes. Simmer for 10 minutes.
5. *Add cream and cheese*: Reduce heat to low and stir in heavy cream and Parmesan. Taste and adjust seasoning with salt and pepper.
6. *Combine*: Add cooked chicken and rigatoni to the sauce, tossing to coat. Add a splash of reserved pasta water if sauce seems too thick.
7. *Serve*: Garnish with fresh parsley and additional Parmesan if desired.

